

Shore bombardment
The USS *Wisconsin* fires one of her nine 16-in guns at an Iraqi shore target during Operation Desert Storm.

THE FIRST GULF WAR

The Gulf War of 1990–91 was a massive naval operation as well as a major air and land campaign. At the time of Saddam Hussein's invasion of Kuwait on August 2, 1990, the US Navy, Royal Navy, Saudi Arabia, and others already had significant naval assets on station. Once Operation Desert Shield—the Coalition operation for the protection of Saudi Arabia—was implemented, the naval presence expanded enormously.

The US had to provide naval logistics for a swelling land army—during the first six months of Desert Shield sealift accounted for over 2 million tons of supplies shipped ashore. Two carrier battlegroups (centered on *Eisenhower* and *Independence*) were on station by August 8, providing huge offshore air capability. Four more carrier battlegroups and several surface warfare battlegroups would soon join them, including two battleships (*Wisconsin* and *Missouri*). The Coalition also enforced a naval embargo, resulting in hundreds of stop-and-search operations in Gulf waters: by January 1991 the US Navy had conducted 6,221 challenges and 749 boardings.

> "YOU'D FLY ALONG THE ROAD, LOOKING FOR SOMETHING. IT WAS UNBELIEVABLE, THE NUMBER OF TARGETS AVAILABLE."
>
> **CAPTAIN ANDREW HALL**, MARINE AV-8B HARRIER PILOT DURING FIRST GULF WAR

On January 17, 1991, Desert Shield turned into Operation Desert Storm, and the shooting war began with a heavy, prolonged air attack on Iraq's forces and infrastructure. Desert Storm opened with naval vessels launching Tomahawk cruise missiles at key targets throughout Iraq, destroying much of Saddam's command-and-control structure. The carrier groups in the Gulf and Red Sea then contributed naval and Marine air assets to the Coalition air campaign, destroying vast amounts of Iraqi military material and killing many thousands of Iraqi troops. Navy E6-AB Prowler ECM aircraft also played a critical role in jamming Iraqi air defenses to open a door for strike aircraft attacks. In total, US Navy and Marine Corps pilots flew some 30,000 sorties from the US carriers during the war.

DENOUEMENT

Out at sea there were skirmishes with Iraqi craft. Lynx helicopters from Royal Navy vessels destroyed 15 Iraqi vessels, including minesweepers and patrol boats, using anti-ship missiles. US vessels wrecked Iraqi positions atop several oil platforms, while naval aircraft took out Iraqi minelayers. When the land offensive opened, not only did Coalition marine forces take leading roles, but US naval units conducted simulated amphibious landings off the Kuwaiti coast to hold the attention of Iraqi coastal troops, who were actually being outflanked from behind. The US battleships delivered huge offshore bombardments. By February 27, offensive operations had effectively ceased and Kuwait was back in Kuwaiti hands.

FIRST GULF WAR



THE FIRST GULF WAR

Date	August 2,1990–April 11, 1991
Location	The Gulf, Red Sea, Kuwait, and Iraq
Result	Coalition victory

COMBATANTS

US-LED COALITION	IRAQ

COMMANDERS

Stanley R. Arthur **Norman Schwartzkopf**	**Saddam Hussein**

FORCES

Ships: c.150 combat and logistical ships, including 6 US carrier battlegroups	**Ships:** c.80 military vessels, mostly gunboats and missile boats

LOSSES

Men: 64 US Marines and US Navy personnel **Ships:** none	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** unknown

Sea Skua anti-ship missile
The British Sea Skua radar-guided anti-ship missile was first used in the Falklands War. A total of 26 missiles were fired during the First Gulf War, sinking 11 Iraqi vessels.

